following orders from authorities, would step in to save the day. Social psychology theorizes that if fear and panic spread in society with an instinct of self-survival taking over, civilization would quickly collapse. As NSA, part of his job was to keep the prime minister abreast of any potential national security threat, including a biological one, to ensure that all impending disasters could be appropriately dealt with. Trust of the people in the government was paramount to maintaining harmony. Sharing a land border with China, it was important for India to track this minutely.

Ajit Doval is described by most of his colleagues as absolutely reliable and an operational genius. Hand-picked by the prime minister in 2014, only recently, after completion of his first term as NSA, he made history by not only being reappointed for a full second term, but also being elevated to the rank of a Cabinet minister.[3]

Reports of the increasing case count of the mystery virus in Wuhan were disturbing. Our Intelligence knew that the Chinese were not divulging the full extent of the damage. Therefore, to keep an eye on the ball, all hands were needed on deck and other trusted experts including officers in the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) would have to be involved. The PMO is situated in one of the two buildings that flank the Rashtrapati Bhavan, culminating at the centre and top of Raisina Hill. It is lined with large brown stones and a royal dome under which is situated the elegant, circular Waiting Area across from the prime minister's chamber. The security detail of the whole complex is handled by the Special Protection Group, with armed men in camouflage uniforms and sharp suits on duty escorting visitors to their meetings. The PMO's architecture or operation makes no modest assumptions about the power it possesses. Some of India's best Civil Service officers and Officers on Special Duty chosen by the prime minister and who form his core team have offices in the building.

On 31 December 2019, the World Health Organization's (WHO) China country office was informed of cases of pneumonia due to unknown aetiology (unknown cause) detected in Wuhan.[4] By 1 January 2020, 27 people were hospitalized[5] and on 3 January, a total of 44 case patients were reported to the WHO by the Chinese national authorities, of which 11 were reported to be severely ill.[6] The statistics were not good. Although the WHO clearly said there was no evidence of human-to-human transmission and that the spread seems to be contained, the reality was that China had not